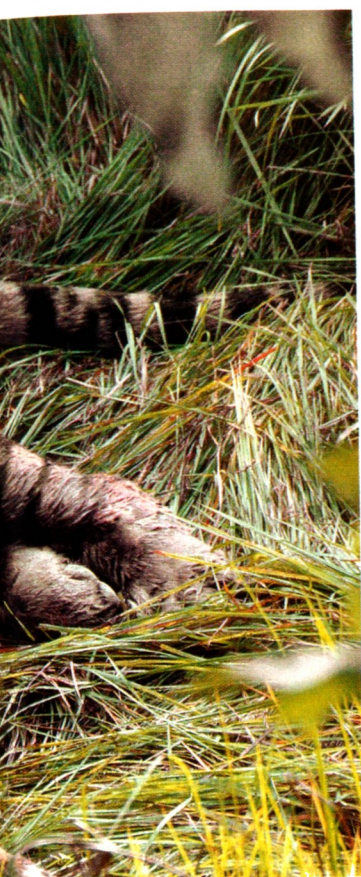
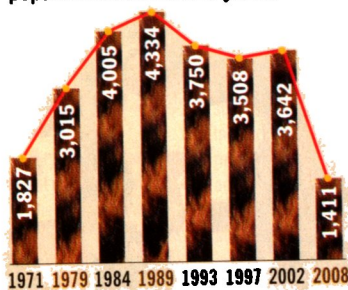




CAT-ASTROPHE

Since a high in the 1980s, India has seen an alarming decline in the tiger population in almost 20 years.



Source: NTCA

CORNERED: An injured tiger (left); forest officials take a pug-mark impression



PREDATOR

last nine years. "Poaching in the state's forests has become a serious problem and requires full attention of the police as many international gangs operate from here," he says. The areas bordering Nepal in the state provide poachers with easy access to international smuggling routes.

Also the tiger's shrinking habitat (less than 4 per cent of forest area against the required 33 per cent of the total geographical area) is pushing the wild cats to the point of no-return. "Where is the priority of the state Government," asks a senior NTCA official, adding, "we had sent numerous warnings and advisories to them, but it seems that they were all dumped." For instance, he says, Chief Minister Mayawati heads the committee steering wildlife, which has not met

even once last year. There is also a state wildlife board which is headed by the chief minister, but this body is consigned to red-tapism. A complaint was lodged by Naresh Dixit, president of the National Journalists Association, with Mayawati against Forest Minister Fateh Bahadur Singh for favouring tainted officers, but nothing has come of it.

The NTCA and the Union Ministry of Environment and Forests's missives to various states to check the diminishing tiger population have met with no action. NTCA had asked the Uttar Pradesh Government to arm its forest officials with speed radar guns to discourage high-speed driving in forests but that advice has not been followed through.

Forest officials in the field face the perpetual problem of limited finances to man the tiger habitats. "We have old staff in the field. We need young and energetic personnel to patrol the forests. Our vehicles are outdated and

firearms don't match those of the poachers," laments P.P. Singh, deputy director, Dudhwa National Park, the state's only tiger reserve. Moreover, the law of the state says that if a forest official were to fire at a poacher during a chase, he would have to contest his own case, should the poacher file a criminal case against him.

Nearly 29,000 hectare of reserved forest area in the state's terai region has been in illegal hands for years which leaves the Forest Department helpless as most of them are backed by politicians. Former wildlife warden Rahul Shukla believes that the NTCA figures actually flatter Uttar Pradesh and that there are not even 100 tigers left in the state.

Responding to the claim that a large number of majestic cats have taken to sugarcane fields and so have not been counted, Shukla says the animals are straying because their prey base is dwindling.

NTCA has rejected the sugarcane tiger theory as an "excuse" and says neither do the camera-trappings show any tigers in the fields nor are there any signs of droppings.

Uttar Pradesh's Forest Department has cut a sorry figure in contrast to Uttarakhand's efforts with their tiger population. The NTCA figures show that the state has only 164 tigers left, down from 240 at the time of the last count, carried out using the pug-mark method that was prone to distortions.

Currently, Uttarakhand's tigers are housed in Jim Corbett and Rajaji National Park and six other sanctuaries. State Principal Chief Conservator of Forests (Wildlife) S.K. Chandola says the state has concentrated on long-range surveillance on poachers and grassland management. Small groups comprising forest personnel, ex-army personnel and members from NGOs walk 10-15 km in the jungle a day and at times stay there to keep an eye on both tigers and potential poachers.

India still houses the most tigers in the world but that number is still falling. Instead of moving swiftly and decisively, the Centre and states are busy contesting each other's claims. ■